

1.6.4 Possible solutions to the BSOD

When a BSOD occurs, the first step is to note down the Stop number, the ‘friendly name’ of the error and also the name of the file that is reported as the cause of the problem. The Stop number will be in hexadecimal format—something like this:

STOP : 0x0000000A (0xDB000000, 0x00000001, 0x00000002, 0xB04FB0DB)

The friendly name will be something like this:

IRQL_NOT_LESS_OR_EQUAL

If the error comes up very briefly, before you can note it down, and the system restarts, you will need to change a setting to tell Windows not to automatically reboot. Right-click My Computer, select the Advanced tab, and click “Startup and Recovery”, in Windows 2000, clear the “Automatically Reboot” checkbox. In Windows XP, click Settings and clear the “Automatic Restart” checkbox. This, of course, assumes that Windows has rebooted normally and you are able to change the setting.

If you are not able to boot normally, restart Windows and press [F8] repeatedly during the POST cycle. This will take you to the Advanced Options menu. Choose Safe Mode. Windows will attempt to load with a minimum set of drivers. If Windows is able to boot into Safe Mode, this most likely means that the problem is with a particular software, and is not hardware-related. If Windows is not able to boot into Safe Mode, restart the computer, bring up the Advanced Options screen (by pressing [F8] during POST) and select “Last Known Good Configuration”. Windows will then attempt to load the last settings where everything worked normally. If that doesn’t work, then it most likely means you have a serious hardware or critical startup system file error. If this error has occurred after any recent hardware additions, remove the hardware and try to boot again.